- You can use *examples* to understand how the features will help your users and to guide your work on the user stories. You can use examples to understand both features and individual user stories.

4.1.1 Features deliver capabilities

As developers, we build features so that end users, and stakeholders in general, can achieve their goals. Users need our software to give them the *capabilities* that will help them contribute to these business goals.

Features are what we deliver to users to support these capabilities. A feature is a tangible piece of functionality that will be valuable for users, that relates closely to what the users actually ask for, and that may or may not be deliverable in a single iteration. It can be delivered relatively independently of other features and be tested by end users in isolation. Features are often used to plan and document releases.

Features are expressed in business terms and in a language that management can understand. If you were writing a user manual, a feature would probably have its own section or subsection. Back in the day when off-the-shelf software was packaged in boxes, features would be what appeared on the side of the package.

Let's look at an example. Flying High Airlines is very proud of its recently introduced Frequent Flyer program. Belonging to the Flying High Frequent Flyer club lets members earn points that they can spend on flights or upgrades and so forth, and it's designed to encourage travellers to book with Flying High rather than a competitor. But management has noticed a high rate of lapsed memberships, which they suspect is due to the cumbersome renewal process. Currently, members need to call Flying High or return a renewal form by non-electronic mail to renew.

Suppose you have identified the capability, "to enable members to renew their membership more easily." Some useful features supporting this capability on the Flying High customer site might be "allow members to renew their membership online" and "notify members when their membership is due for renewal." To support these capabilities, you could define features such as "renew membership online" or "notify members that their membership is due for renewal by email" (see figure 4.4).

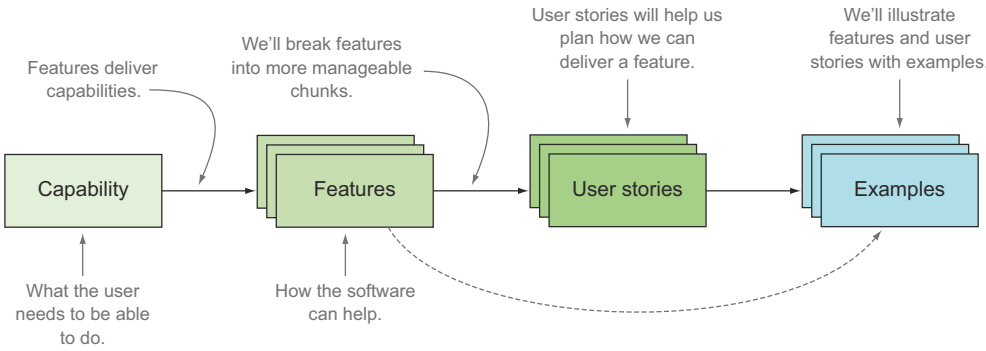


Figure 4.3 Features deliver capabilities to stakeholders. We'll use user stories to plan how we'll deliver a feature. We'll use examples to illustrate features and user stories.